The CareLeaders

Programme brochure

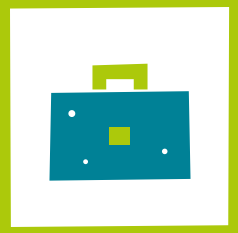
Apprenticeships and jobs Aged 18 to 25

Care to Work



An apprenticeships and jobs programme for care experienced young people aged 18 to 25, commissioned by councils as corporate parents.

Contents



Apprenticeships and jobs

Care to Work

03 Why we created it

04 What it is

05 Who it is for

06 How it works

07 Step by step

08 The timeline

09 Training the hosts

10 What changes, and what you keep

11 Case study: Suffolk

12 In their words

13 Your facilitator

14 Reaching young people

15 Getting started

Why we created it

Care leavers are more than twice as likely to be out of work, education or training.

Your council has a duty to prepare these young people for adult life. It is also one of the largest employers in your area. Those two facts rarely meet.

Care to Work joins them: apprenticeships and jobs inside your own council first, with managers trained to help care leavers stay. The gap is not ambition. It is a first chance, and an adult at work who understands where a young person has come from.

That's why we created Care to Work.

The gap

40%

of care leavers aged 19 to 21 in England are not in education, employment or training.

15%

is the estimate for all young people the same age.

Source: Department for Education, Children looked after in England including adoptions, reporting year 2025 (year ending 31 March 2025). The 15% comes from the Labour Force Survey.

What it is

An 11-month programme that starts inside your council. We train hiring managers and personal advisers first, then open apprenticeships and jobs in your own teams. We support your council and community to offer jobs to care leavers.

A set-up
Three design labs with your young people, months 1 to 3

Your own brand
Named and signed off by your young people

Apprenticeships and jobs
Five or more roles for 18 to 25 year olds

Trained managers
One for every role, trained with your PAs

The Managers Toolkit
A workbook, induction packs and online modules

Support that lasts
90 days of support in a new job



Who this programme is for

For	Councils, as corporate parents and as large local employers
Young people	Care experienced, aged 18 to 25
Trained first	Personal advisers (PAs) and hiring managers
Led by	A named project lead and executive sponsor in your council

What it sets out to do

Care leavers become your colleagues.

Three objectives, for every council we work with. Everyone who supports a young person is trained first, so the job works for them from day one.

Opportunities

Real first chances, starting with your council

- Apprenticeships and jobs in your own council first.
- A trained manager for every role.
- Roles ring-fenced by HR, with backing from your chief executive.

Support

The adults around them, trained before day one

- PAs and hiring managers trained before any young person starts.
- Our Getting the Job session before young people apply.
- Keeping the Job: support over the first 90 days.

Legacy

A programme your council owns

- A brand named by your young people, and a communications plan.
- The Managers Toolkit and trained managers, so your teams can run the next cohort.
- A final report on what worked, and what to do next.

What young people get

- A real, paid job in your council
- A trained manager on the other side of it
- Their own PA alongside them at every step
- Help to apply, through our Getting the Job session
- A route on to The Care Leaders Fellowship

How the programme works, in three steps.

Every council has its own services, employers and young people, so we don't sell an off-the-shelf scheme. It runs for 11 months and starts with a set-up built with your young people.

1

We set it up together

Months 1 to 3. Three design labs with your young people: what good support looks like, a name and brand they choose, and sign-off. We build your communications plan and governance alongside them.

2

We find the roles

HR agrees how roles are ring-fenced, and directors pledge roles and a manager each. Five or more apprenticeships and jobs for 18 to 25 year olds.

3

We prepare the hosts, then go live

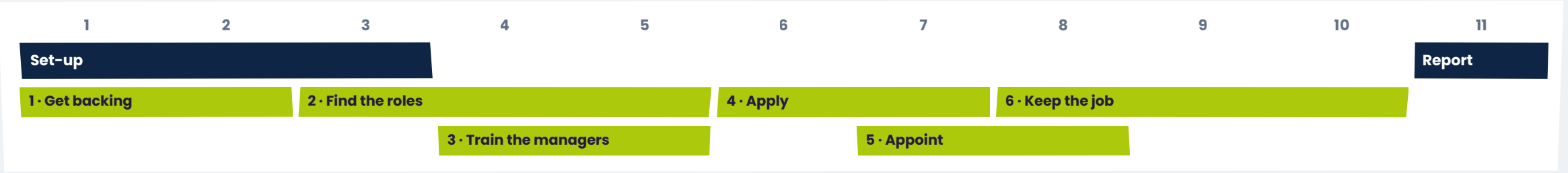
Managers and PAs are trained first. Then a six-week campaign calls care leavers to apply, and we support every new starter through their first 90 days.

Want work experience too? Our work experience strand, for 16 to 18 year olds, runs alongside on the same set-up. A young person can go from work experience at 17 to a job at 18, with the same PA.

Aged 18 to 25

Apprenticeships and jobs, step by step.

Care leavers get real jobs in your council, with a manager trained to help them stay.



1 — Months 1 to 2

Get backing

HR agrees how roles are ring-fenced, and your chief executive backs it.

→

2 — Months 3 to 5

Find the roles

Directors pledge roles and a manager each. HR approves them.

→

3 — Months 4 to 5

Train the managers

Two labs, then two training sessions, the second with your PAs.

→

4 — Months 6 to 7

Apply

PAs put care leavers forward. Our Getting the Job session helps them apply.

→

5 — Months 7 to 8

Appoint

Your managers interview and appoint, and your council pays the wages.

→

6 — Months 8 to 10

Keep the job

Three manager and PA sessions over the first 90 days.

Your part

- HR agrees the route
- Directors agree roles by month 3
- Departments fund the roles

5+ apprenticeships and jobs in your council. A target we work towards with you.

At a glance

The programme in numbers.

11 Months
From set-up to handover

3 Design labs
With your young people, in months 1 to 3

6 Steps
One simple route

5+ Jobs
Apprenticeships and jobs for 18 to 25 year olds

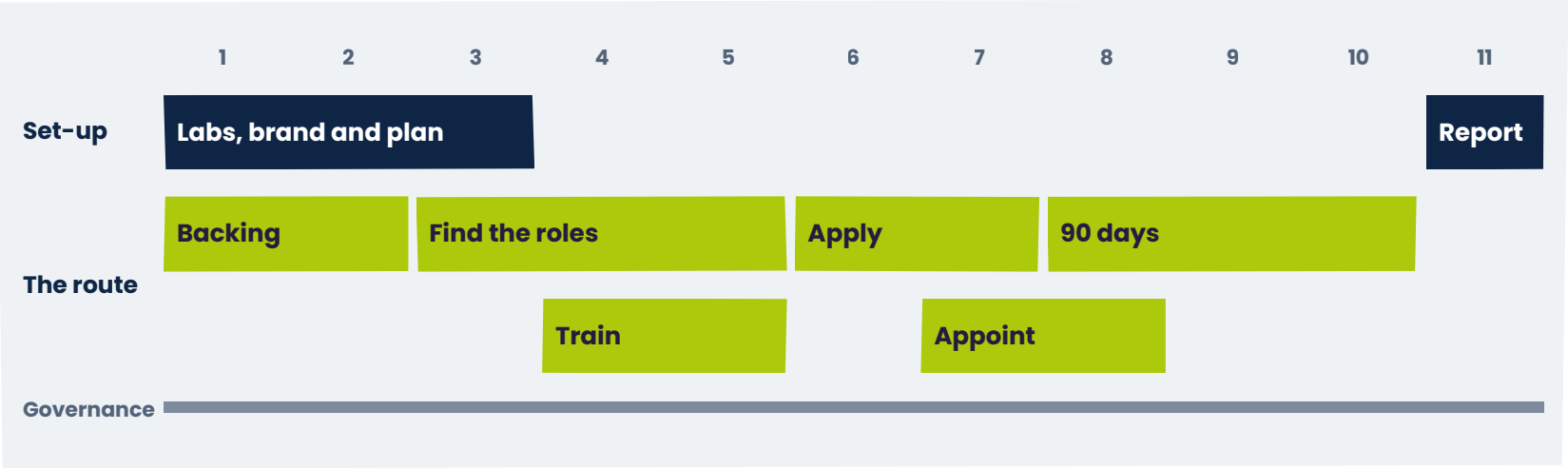
1 Trained manager
For every role

90 Days
Of support when a young person starts work

The timeline

Eleven months to handover.

The route runs on an 11-month clock, from set-up to handover. Exact dates are agreed with you at the start.



Month 3
Brand signed off. Directors have agreed the roles.

Month 5
Managers trained. HR has approved the roles.

Month 8
Care leavers start work.

Month 11
Final report presented in person, and handover.

Roles keep to time if your directors agree them by month 3 and HR approves them by month 5. Council recruitment and checks take months, so they start early.

Every manager trained before day one.

Managers learn our Access to Opportunity framework: apply with your PA, meet your manager, start work. Their toolkit stays with them online, so the next manager in your council can learn it too.

What managers get

Access to Opportunity
Our three-step framework for every manager.

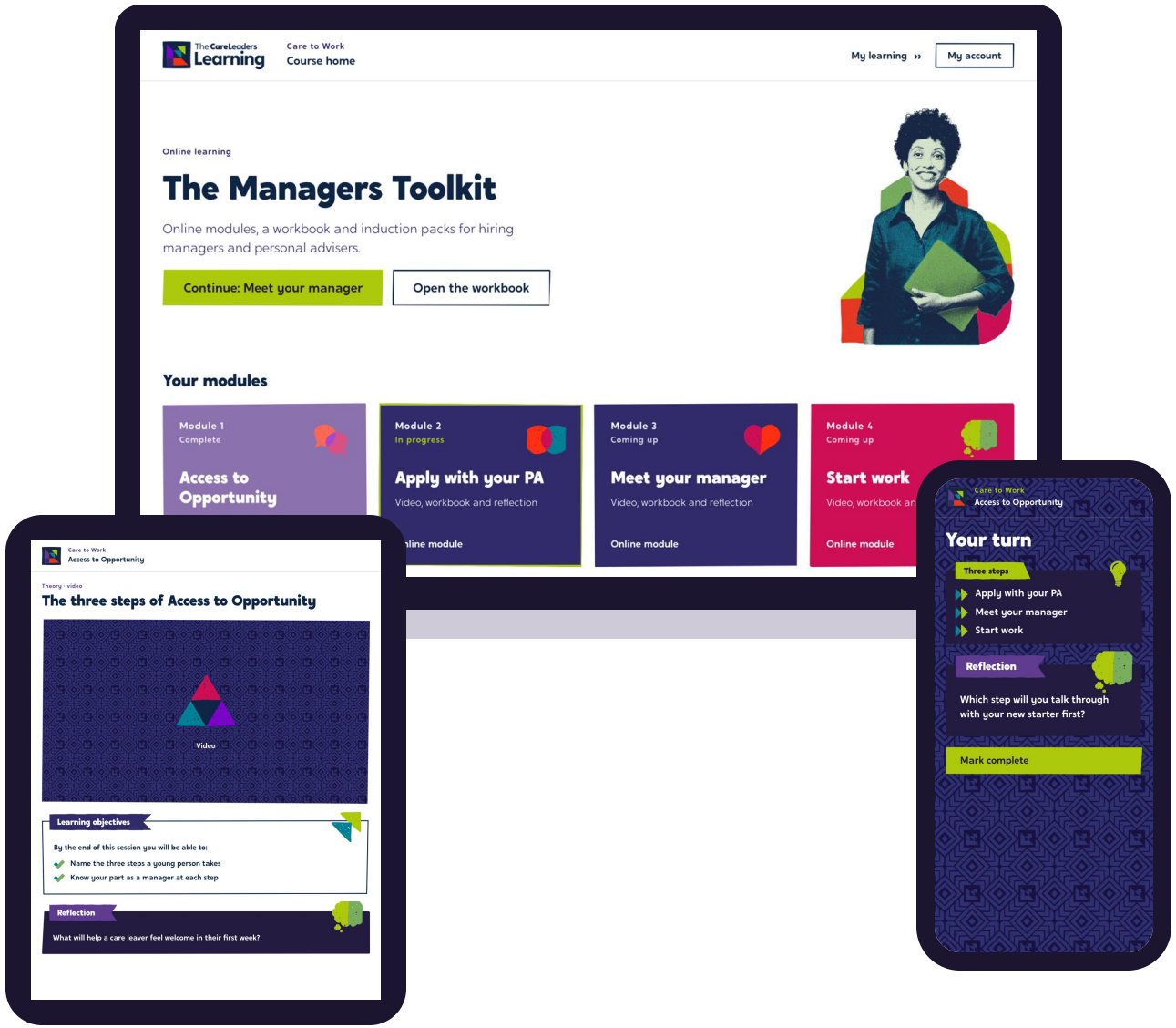
The Managers Toolkit
Two sessions, a workbook and online modules.

PAs trained alongside
With managers, not separately.

Induction packs
On paper and online, for every new starter.

Online, your way
A SCORM file for your system, or The Care Leaders Online.

Keeping the Job
Three manager and PA sessions over 90 days.



What changes

Care leavers in work, starting with your council.

01 **For young people.** A real job designed around what they told us they need, with a trained manager on the other side of it.

02 **For managers.** Hiring managers across your council who know what care experience means, and how to hire and keep a care leaver well.

03 **For your council.** Corporate parenting you can count, a brand and a toolkit you reuse every year, and evidence that came from young people.

5+

Apprenticeships and jobs in your council, each with a trained manager

a target we work towards with you

One final report, presented in person: who took part, what young people, hosts and your teams told us, what worked, and your next phase.

What you keep

Nothing we build stays ours.

With the managers and PAs we train, your teams can run the next cohort without us.

- Your local brand, with guidelines, templates and a Canva workspace
- The communications plan, to reach young people, hosts and employers every year
- The final report: who took part, what everyone told us, and what to do next
- The Managers Toolkit: training, a workbook, induction packs and online modules
- Ring-fenced roles, and an HR route you can use again

Case study

Suffolk County Council

Suffolk County Council

November 2022 to October 2024. Programme design, co-design, coaching and film.

60+ people at the employer launch

5 ring-fenced council apprenticeships agreed in the first year

6 care leavers in council apprenticeships, 4 completed or on track

Up to 40 young people gained qualifications through the Skills Academy

From corporate parenting to community parenting.

Care leavers in Suffolk had a corporate parent in the council, but not many of the things a parent gives you: a first job, a contact who knows someone, a place to learn how work works. The council wanted to change that from the inside, starting with its own jobs. Care to Work is built on what we learned there.

Listen

A two-day stakeholder review across seven groups, from care leavers to managers and HR. Goodwill everywhere, routes into work almost nowhere.

Design

A six-phase programme: a brand co-designed with young people, a comms strategy, induction and supervisor training, and a project board.

Open doors

An Innovation Board of local business owners and an employer event. Placements went live in Waste, Fire and Rescue, and Home First.

Keep it going

Coaching, apprentice onboarding and sustainability planning, then films with care leavers telling their own stories.

What changed

The employer launch drew over 60 people, and the council's own report recorded "an overwhelming number of opportunities" for young people. The NHS offered a six-week course for 30 care experienced people.

pwc

Also: PwC. In September 2024, 30 care leavers from Kent, West Sussex, East Sussex and Suffolk spent a day at PwC's London office, through our councils and networks.

In their words

They have supported us to create a sustainable programme which offers ring-fenced work opportunities, including apprenticeships to our care leavers, every year.

Matthew Cooke, Virtual School Head, Suffolk County Council
On the Suffolk employment programme, 2023





Luke Rodgers BEM
Founder and CEO, The Care Leaders

Your facilitator

From care leaver to care leader.

Luke went into care at 10. At 15 he was living in a bed and breakfast, and at 18 in a caravan. He gave his first keynote at 19 and has spent his career since inside children's services, as a consultant, trainer, board member and national engagement lead.

He has built routes into work with councils and employers. With Suffolk County Council he designed a programme that gave care leavers council work experience and ring-fenced apprenticeships, with placements in Waste, Fire and Rescue and Home First, and an employer launch that drew over 60 people.

He worked with PwC to open its New World, New Skills days to care leavers, and leads The Care Leaders' employment and pathways work with councils.

He founded The Care Leaders in 2017, and it has since worked with 36 local authorities and national bodies, including the Department for Education and the NHS. He knows what an employer needs before they say yes, and what a young person needs to stay in work once they start.

- **Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award**
  iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026
- **British Empire Medal**
  2018, for commitment to children and families
- **Knowledge Equity Fellow**
  Saïd Business School, University of Oxford, 2020 to 2021
- **Social Entrepreneur Fellow**
  School for Social Entrepreneurs, 2015 to 2017

A campaign your young people put their name to.

Through the set-up and the campaign, we give your council everything it needs to reach care leavers, hosts and employers, under a brand your young people choose.

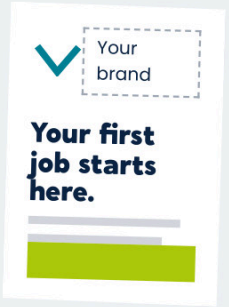
How we help young people apply and take part

- Every PA names a care leaver at the start, so the programme starts with real young people.
- Your young people name the brand, so the campaign sounds like them.
- A six-week campaign calls care leavers to apply, through their PAs.
- Our Getting the Job session helps them apply for roles, with ID ready.
- Managers and PAs stay with each new starter through their first 90 days.

What we build with you



Brand guidelines
Named by your young people



Campaign posters
For the six-week campaign



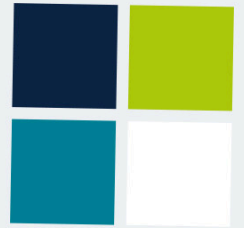
How it works
For care leavers and PAs



Induction packs
For every new starter



Communications plan
For young people, hosts and employers



Canva workspace
Templates your teams can edit

The CareLeaders

Care to Work

Apprenticeships and jobs

Getting started

Four steps to your first cohort.

1 Get in touch

Email us, or scan the QR code and fill in our short form about your council.

2 Have an initial call

We reply within 3 working days to book a call about your young people, your roles and your dates.

3 We provide a quote

A clear price, and what is included.

4 We set it up with you

Your young people are in the first design lab within weeks.

hello@thecareleaders.com

Scan to tell us about your council

A five-minute form that gives us what we need for our first call.

What we need from you

- A named project lead and an executive sponsor
- PAs released for the kick-off and the training
- HR agrees the route: ring-fence or guaranteed interview
- Directors agree roles by month 3, and HR approves them by month 5
- Departments fund the roles and pay the wages
- Managers released for the labs and the training

Commissioned by your council as corporate parent. Contact us for a price.

iese Awards GOLD Winner 2026 The Public Sector Transformation Awards

Children & Young People Now Awards 2023 Winner

Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award, iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026.
Children & Young People Now Workforce Development Award 2023.

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